

Fong See Video Transcript

In 1871, 14-year-old Fong See left China in search of his father and his fortune in the United States. His story is told here by his great-granddaughter, Lisa See, who documented her family's history in *On Gold Mountain*.

When I was young, I often stayed with my grandparents in Chinatown. Our family has an antique store there, and I spent hours building forts under altars or reading books in a Buddha's lap. When I was older, I stopped playing and started listening to stories of how the family my family triumphed over racist laws and discrimination. I also heard the Saga of my great-grandfather, the head of our family, that's him there, Fong See, in 1871, when he was 14 years old. Fong See came to Gold Mountain to America from China alone. He was searching for his father, an herbalist who'd been recruited by the Central Pacific Railroad to come and care for Chinese workers, but by the time Fong See arrived, the Transcontinental Railroad was finished. Unemployment was rising, and the Chinese were competing with whites for the same scarce jobs. Like other non-white races, they did not receive equal protection under the law, and so they became easy targets for growing frustrations. Violence erupted throughout the West. In Los Angeles, San Francisco, and in Denver alone, angry mobs beat and murdered hundreds of Chinese laborers.

By the time Fong See found his father, who was running an herb store in Sacramento, his father was ready to go home to China, but Fong See stayed. He took over the store, changed the merchandise from Chinese herbs to American garments, and hoped that he might now find his fortune on Gold Mountain. Unfortunately, anti-Chinese prejudice continued to grow. In 1882, the US Congress passed the Chinese Exclusion Act, which prohibited all Chinese laborers from entering the country. As a merchant, Fong See faced fewer restrictions, but the new law shut the door on friends and relatives still in China who wished to immigrate. So Fong See found a way around these restrictions. While formally registering his own Merchant status with the government, he registered his brothers and friends as Merchants too. Over time, this one document helped an entire family, my family, slip through a fast-closing door.

Meanwhile, a new member of my family walked through Fong See's own door. Leticy Pruitt was an 18-year-old runaway from Oregon. She was desperate for a job, which Fong SE reluctantly gave her, but she quickly demonstrated a keen business sense and, more importantly, a friendliness with white customers that he would never, could never, have. To Fong See, Leticy Pruitt was clearly good for business, and for him. They decided to marry; however, an 1880 law made it illegal for a Caucasian and Chinese couple to obtain a marriage license, so they hired a lawyer to create a contract marriage, then they moved to Los Angeles. By 1917, 20 years later, Fong See had five children, including my grandpa Eddie. The family prospered despite continued oppression, thanks to a combination of hard work and clever business tactics.

In Los Angeles, Fong See sold imported antiques, some genuine and some enhanced thanks to turpentine tar or a good soak and horse manure. He attracted customers with tickets to see a stuffed mermaid. He told wild stories about new found treasures, and he refused to play the expected role of the meek and timid Chinese man. Instead, Fong SE stood his ground with white customers, bargained firmly, even turned them away if their offers were unreasonable, but they came back often and paid double when they did.

By 1919, Fong See had five stores in Los Angeles and was easily among the wealthiest Chinese in America. But because he was Chinese, the Alien Land Act said he couldn't own land, so he lived in a rented apartment above one of the stores. Because he was Chinese, the Naturalization law said he couldn't become a citizen, so he couldn't vote. Because he was Chinese, the Exclusion Act still threatened every business trip he made to and from China, and then there was Angel Island. Angel Island sits in San Francisco Bay just beyond Alcatraz. When it opened in 1910, officials called it the Ellis Island of the West, but it wasn't. At Ellis Island, European immigrants could be processed in a day. Here, Chinese Travelers were detained for weeks, months, some over a year as interrogators and agents determined their fate. Although Fong See was never detained at Angel Island, his brother Fong Yan was. In 1910, Fong Yan returned from a visit to China and was found to have hookworm. After a week in detention, he was about to be deported when Fong See arrived to pay for medical treatment. Great Uncle Yun was lucky. Between 1910 and 1935, one out of four Chinese immigrants were denied entrance to the United States. But just as many of my relatives yearned for a new home, Fong See began to yearn for the old.

In 1919, Fong See returned to his childhood Village. He was received and acted like royalty. He bought land and homes for his extended family, food and provisions for his fellow villagers. He built a hotel and paved the main street. He also followed the Chinese custom of taking another wife. Fong See married Nan Hong, a young woman from his district. But in order to support this life, he still had to make money in America. He returned to Los Angeles in 1922. By then, Ticy had learned of his new wife. She sadly arranged to have their own contract marriage voided. Half of the business and all of their children went with her, including Grandpa Eddie. Fong See focused his attention on business he had to since the Immigration Act of 1924 kept Nan Hong, his new wife, out of the country until 1928.

By 1935, Fong See was 75, the father of two large families, financially secure and ready to retire. So he returned to China to his fine house, respectful neighbors, and yet another marriage, only to leave 2 years later when the Japanese invaded. Before the attack on Pearl Harbor he returned to China for one more pre-war Bargain Hunt and was nearly arrested by Port Authorities.

But to Fong See, maneuvering authorities was how you made a life on Gold Mountain. Perseverance was essential because prejudice and discrimination were always present, always even in death. It was Fong See's desire to rest alongside Ticy, his Caucasian wife, but in 1957, Forest Lawn Cemetery said no; he would have to be buried in the non-white section. Grandpa Eddie and others objected, so he was buried in Rosale Cemetery in the section allotted to

Los Angeles's most important Pioneer families. That is the story I learned in my great-grandfather's antique store, a true story of two countries, two races, but only one family... mine.